in the finals.

Even as PKL sees the return of star Iranian players like Fazel Atrachali and Mohammadreza Shadloui Chiyaneh (second most expensive at Rs 2.07 crore), there are others like Korea's Jang Kun Lee, who is eagerly awaiting a return to PKL after four years and will play for three-time champions Patna Pirates. "A lot of fans texted me on my DMs [direct messages] that they missed me. I really loved my time playing in India and I am very excited and happy to be back," he says in an email interview. "I want to raise my game and test myself against the absolute best players."

India is the bastion of kabaddi and its name is synonymous with the sport but, over the past decade, nations like Iran and Taiwan have risen through the ranks and given Indian teams—both men's and women's—a run for their money. If anything, the high level of play is helping more international players to up their game. It helps that the league is long—lasting three months—giving them plenty of match exposure. "Earlier, Pakistan was our [biggest] rival, but Iran now knows all skills and tactics [from PKL]," says Sunil. "That's why they are getting better. Now there are tough matches against other countries which wasn't the case earlier."

Both Sachin and Sunil concur that PKL has made kabaddi more accessible to fans. "Earlier, if we'd win an Asian Games gold medal nobody would know, but PKL has enhanced the reputation of kabaddi by providing such a big platform." The addition of video analysis has helped players to rectify their mistakes and grow. More emphasis on fitness in a sport known for its body contact has helped players increase their longevity. With 22 matches spread across three months, they will need all the fitness to put their best foot forward. ■

–Suhani Singh

SPORTS

Hitting Their Stride

Under Harmanpreet Singh's stewardship, the Indian hockey team has had a string of recent successes

On September 17, the final of the Asian Champions Trophy stood goalless at the end of the third quarter. Defending champions India started favourites, having won all six matches, including a 3-0 rout of the other finalists, China. As the players caught their breath, skipper Harmanpreet Singh, who has earned the moniker of 'Sarpanch' as a dominant leader of the pack, spoke up: "I simply asked the team to ensure that we had enough ball possession and made the most of the few opportunities." Nine minutes from the final hooter, the Sarpanch took charge. He made a darting run towards the Chinese goal line, skipping past two defenders before feeding Jugraj Singh, who scored. It added another triumph to India's kitty, continuing their stellar run under coach Craig Fulton, which includes gold at the 2023 Asian Games, followed by bronze at the Paris Olympics.

Harmanpreet's consistency has earned him his third nomination for FIH Player of the Year



ANI

"Our mindset has changed and we have managed to put a plan in place for every situation. We won the quarterfinal at the Olympics against Great Britain despite being a man down. This readiness has helped us win back-to-back medals," he says.

At the Asian Champions Trophy, Singh scored his 200th goal against South Korea and finished as India's top scorer, just like he did at the Olympics and the Asian Games. The consistency has earned him his third nomination for FIH Player of the Year. "Individual recognition is a huge honour, but it's only possible because of other players. The biggest compliment is to realise that hockey is back in the limelight," he says.

A number of young players that Fulton had picked for the Asian Champions Trophy will be in contention again, as the team gears up for a two-match series against Germany. The revival of the Hockey India League, scheduled for December, has Singh's attention too.

"As part of the league in my youth, I rubbed shoulders with seasoned players. Besides improving my game, it helped me gain confidence. So, it's certainly going to be a vital experience for the younger lot," he says. Given his stature these days, the Sarpanch would certainly know. ■

– Shail Desai